

capture real life, and part of the brilliance of *The Bicycle Thief*' cinematography in particular is the sense it gives of a world that is continuing beyond the frame—by briefly following incidents away from the main characters, or including real life going on in the background of a frame. To strip away the artificiality of studio movies, neorealist directors often cast untrained actors, as Vittorio De Sica did in *The Bicycle Thief*. Enzo Staiola, the boy who plays Bruno with such tough and emotional directness, was spotted by the director in the crowd watching him film while on location.

Lasting influence

Italian neorealism had already been championed by directors such as Luchino Visconti, with his 1943 masterpiece *Ossessione* (p.78). Yet what gives De Sica's movie in particular its lasting power is the magnificence of its filmmaking. The sweep, design, and movement

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This is poverty's authentic sting: banal and horrible loss of dignity.

Peter Bradshaw
The Guardian, 2008

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On its release in Italy, the movie met with some hostility for its negative portrayal of the country. However, it received great reviews around the rest of the world.

of its black-and-white photography as it follows Antonio and Bruno on their quest give an epic quality that engrosses the viewer in their lives. Directors such as Ken Loach and Satyajit Ray have cited De Sica's movie as the most important influence on their careers. Such was its impact on its release that it was hard for innovative filmmakers not to think in terms of real streets, snatches of life, and ordinary people as the stuff of cinema. In the years that followed, movements such as the *Nouvelle Vague* (New Wave) in France and the “kitchen sink” dramas of the UK marked a shift in filmmaking toward this more naturalistic and candid approach. ■



Vittorio De Sica Director

Born in 1901 to a poor family, Vittorio De Sica grew up in Naples, Italy, working as an office boy to support his family. He got his first movie part at just 17. His good looks and natural screen presence soon turned him into a matinee idol. When he met writer Cesare Zavattini, De Sica became a serious director and a leading exponent of Italian neorealist movie. With Zavattini, he made *Shoeshine* (1946) and *The Bicycle Thief*, both heart-breaking studies of postwar poverty in Italy that won special Oscars in years before the foreign movie category was established. After the box-office disaster of relentlessly bleak *Umberto D.* (1952), De Sica returned to lighter movies, such as a trilogy of romantic comedies *Yesterday, Today, and Tomorrow* (1963), and to acting. He died in 1974.

Key movies

1948 *The Bicycle Thief*
1952 *Umberto D.*
1963 *Yesterday, Today, and Tomorrow*